

Parole review follows drug test errors

Nearly 6,000 inmates in California may have been falsely flagged, hurting their chances for release.

By Salvador Hernandez

The California Department of Corrections and Rehabilitation is reviewing hundreds of state parole hearings to see if any inmates who were denied parole were rejected because of faulty drug tests.

Nearly 6,000 drug tests in California prisons are believed to have yielded false positives between April and July last year, and attorneys for the Board of Parole are now conducting a review of inmate files to determine if any of them need to appear before the parole board again to be reconsidered, according to officials with CDCR.

If any inmates were denied parole because of the faulty tests, they could be owed a new hearing before the parole board, said attorneys representing inmates affected by the defective drug tests.

The review is already underway and will determine if “without the positive drug screening, there is sufficient evidence to support an incarcerated person’s denial of parole,” CDCR spokesperson Emily Humpal said in a statement.

If there isn’t enough evidence to support incarceration other than the drug test, a new hearing will be scheduled.

CDCR officials declined to provide details as to how many parole hearings were being reviewed, and whether any parole hearings had been rescheduled since the process began. More information will be available after the review is complete, the department said.

Representatives at UnCommon Law, a nonprofit advocacy group for inmates seeking parole, said parole board officials told their attorneys that the review involves at least 459 parole hearings, as well as dozens of

[See Opioids, A7]



LUKE JOHNSON Los Angeles Times

NANCY RODRIGUES adds flowers to a growing memorial in front of Baldwin Park City Hall on Sunday.

Officer and civilian killed in Baldwin Park shooting

City’s mayor calls it ‘a night of tragedy for our community’

By Grace Toohey, Richard Winton, Matthew Ormseth, Ruben Vives and Roger Vincent

A young Baldwin Park police officer, who loved the Dodgers and was an avid snowboarder, was killed in a shooting late Saturday that also left a civilian dead and

another officer injured.

Officer Samuel Riveros, 35, was identified Sunday as the officer who died, according to the Los Angeles County Sheriff’s Department. He had been rushed to Los Angeles County-USC Medical Center but was pronounced dead at the hospital, according to medical examiner’s records. The injured officer, Anthony Pi-

mentel, was released from the hospital Sunday.

The identities of the male suspect accused of firing at the officers and the civilian man found shot to death near the shooting were not released as of Sunday afternoon. It appeared that the civilian was fatally shot before officers arrived.

“It’s extremely tragic to have to deal with this,” Bal-

dwin Park Police Chief Robert A. López said as he fought back tears during an early Sunday morning news conference.

López said Riveros loved to travel to Dodgers games and watch the team play at different stadiums.

“Officer Riveros gave his life in service to others, a profound testament to his

[See Officer, A12]

Environmental law nearing a redo

Two bills seek to loosen landmark legislation in California. Passing them would send a signal that ‘we’re ready to build,’ proponents say.

By Liam Dillon

When a landmark state environmental law threatened to halt enrollment at UC Berkeley, legislators stepped in and wrote an exemption. When the Sacramento Kings were about to leave town, lawmakers brushed the environmental rules aside for the team’s new arena. When the law stymied the renovation of

the state Capitol, they acted once again.

Lawmakers’ willingness to poke holes in the California Environmental Quality Act for specific projects without overhauling the law in general has led commentators to describe the changes as “Swiss cheese CEQA.”

Now, after years of nibbling at it, Gov. Gavin Newsom and the Legislature are going in with the knives.

Two proposals have advanced rapidly through the Legislature: one to wipe away the law for most urban housing developments, the other to weaken the rules for most everything else. Legal experts say the efforts would be the most profound changes to CEQA in generations. Newsom not only endorsed the bills last month, but also put them on a fast track to approval by proposing their passage as part of

the state budget, which bypasses normal committee hearings and means they could become law within weeks.

“This is the biggest opportunity to do something big and bold, and the only impediment is us,” Newsom said when announcing his support for the legislation.

Nearly the entire 55-year history of the California Environmental Quality Act has

[See Overhaul, A7]

A wide field for state’s next top leader

Democrats hear from gubernatorial hopefuls at annual convention in Anaheim. Notably absent: Kamala Harris.

By Laura J. Nelson, Seema Mehta and Hannah Fry

California’s most loyal Democrats got a good look this weekend at the wide field of gubernatorial candidates jockeying to replace Gov. Gavin Newsom at the state Democratic Party’s annual convention in Anaheim, with a few chiding former vice president and potential rival Kamala Harris.

The Democrats running for governor in 2026 hurried among caucus meetings, floor speeches and after-parties, telling their personal stories and talking up their bona fides for tackling some of California’s most entrenched problems, including housing affordability and the rising cost of living.

All the hand-shaking and selfies were done in the absence of Harris, who would be the most prominent candidate in the race, and who has not said whether she’ll run for governor in 2026 or seek the White House again in 2028.

The most visible candidates at the convention were former state Senate President Pro Tem Toni Atkins, former U.S. Secretary of Health and Human Services Xavier Becerra, businessman Stephen J. Clooback, Lt. Gov. Eleni Kounalakis and former state Controller

[See Democrats, A6]

Fighting (and four-letter) words

Democrats are done with decorum, writes Mark Z. Barabak. **NATION, A5**

A vow to stick to party values

Help the vulnerable, speakers urge, including the working class. **A6**

Mexico holds a historic vote

Nation is the first in the world to have its citizens cast ballots to elect thousands of judges. **WORLD, A4**

Creatives try to manage AI fears

Big Tech and Hollywood are at an AI crossroads, but a few brave souls are diving in. **BUSINESS, A9**

Trans athlete wins at finals

AB Hernandez triumphs at California track and field championships amid Trump threat. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 77/60. **B6**

Opinion Voices A11
Comics E4-5

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Sound it out, California: Phonics is back in class

Teachers report success with the skills-based approach, which may soon become law

By Jenny Gold and Kate Sequeira

To look inside Julie Celestial’s kindergarten classroom in Long Beach is to peer into the future of reading in California.

During a recent lesson, 25 kindergartners gazed at the whiteboard, trying to sound out the word “bee.” They’re learning the long “e” sound, blending words such as “Pete” and “cheek” — words that they’ll soon be able to read in this lesson’s accompanying book.

Celestial was teaching something new for Long Beach Unified: phonics.

“It’s pretty cool to watch,” she said. “I’m really anticipating that there’s going to be a lot less reluctant readers and struggling readers now that the district has made this shift.”



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

KINDERGARTNERS Gabby Kim, left, and Ellie Such answer questions during a literacy lesson at Mark Twain Elementary School in Long Beach last month.

These phonics-based lessons are on the fast track to become law in California under a sweeping bill moving through the Legislature that will mandate how schools teach reading, a rare action in a state that generally emphasizes local school district control over dictating instruction.

The bill is the capstone to decades of debate and controversy in California on how best to teach reading amid stubbornly low test scores. Gov. Gavin Newsom has pledged his support, setting aside \$200 million to fund teacher training on the new approach in the May revise of his 2025-26 budget proposal.

“It’s a big deal for kids, and it’s a big step forward — a very big one,” said Marshall Tuck, chief executive of EdVoice, an education advocacy group. [See Phonics, A12]



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